

The Home of the Harpies

An inquiry into pathological familial interactions

Yat

We are all susceptible to mental disorder; each of us is endowed with a unique history of experience - a history of frustrations and gratifications. When either of them falls short or remains too much, we will probably be mad.

- Yat

'I was a good boy. I was a bad adolescent. I am a mad man.'

The schizoid and the schizophrenic are no fiction in our contemporary world: they stroll like ghosts in our streets; they feel no real feeling, act no true action; they are just machines par excellence with no intrinsic value. There is a spatio-temporal split between their bodies and their souls - the self detaches its being from the awkward, worthless conglomeration of cells and functions as a cool and hypercritical observer. It is denied participation in interpersonal processes any more; instead, a system of false selves is assumed in virtually all forms of human interactions. Really, the schizoid, to the extreme, the schizophrenic, is the greatest actor in the world and well deserves an Oscar Academy Award in his transactions with himself, with others and the world. Although he is acutely aware of his needs and cravings, he always resolves to act the contrary. He makes good friends with those he hates; but frowns at the girl he loves. There is no sense in his world at all. The universe, at large, is a perpetual threat to his vulnerable self; it is never a benign world, but is utterly desperate, hostile and wanton. Thus, the self withdraws to its inner reality, creating a fata morgana or a castle in the air and abides in it, entertaining itself with autism and phantasy. However, the whole process is a vicious circle: the experiential and emotional structures of the self grow more and more jejune as they interact bootlessly with their phantoms, which in turn reinforces the barrenness and sterility of the self and ad infinitum, until it is reduced to ruin and debris. In the schizophrenic state, the self merely dies and the world is but nothing - no love can exist; no man can dwell within and without.

The weird yet sad world of the schizoid, or else the schizophrenic, is probably a derivative complex of pathological familial interactions. In fact, many forms of functional mental disorder can be brought into parental-familial matrix - the affect field of the family is so profound that it nearly determines the 'fate' and the life chances

of the individual concerned; he will tarry inside this rose, otherwise weed garden until his death unless he is aware of its existence and actively transcending it. It is interesting to see that the schizoid or the schizophrenic was a good child but a bad adolescent as described by his parents; yet, instead of being good or bad, the schizophrenic chooses to be mad.

'Despair in the Pandora's Box - cases of schizophrenia and schizoid personality'

Mr. W was my acquaintance several years ago, when I was in Form Three. At that time, he was my classmate and almost inaccessible to interpersonal communication. He was a quiet, withdrawn but obedient student, studying diligently and seldom seen playing. Everything was normal that year though he behaved secretively at times. But his actions became bizarre and unpredictable in Form Four - he dressed strangely in the campus; in his lessons, he tried to disturb his teachers by standing up suddenly and speaking inconsistently. In Form Five, his condition deteriorated to schizophrenia. He did a lot of mad things in the school. He wore his sun-glasses when he was attending his lessons and maintained that it was Jesus, not Judas committed suicide by hanging on a tree. He did not even have a pass in the subjects he took for School Certificate Examination and dropped out of school eventually. No more information of him can be obtained.

Mr. X is one of my 'old good' friends. He is twenty-one years of age, bony and quite masculine. For years, he has sustained an inadequate and perhaps pathological relationship with girls. In fact, he cannot develop durable friendship or love with girls. Once or twice, he admits that he cannot believe in such relationship and holds that no such friendship ever exists. When he develops, or rather induces a considerable emotional attachment of a girl to him, he will deliberately hurt her by neglect, sarcasm and insults. He behaves as if he were very casual in his status, excellence and achievements, but he is at all very serious about them. Being secretive and concealing in his personal affairs, his feelings and his self, he never exposes himself to others. He lies frequently to his friends, lest they would betray him or hurt him. His familial interactions are poor and meagre - he does not even want to see his family and becomes a Catholic (and wants to be a Father as well) when his family is converted to Protestantism. He actively avoids emotional involvement with others. Clinically, he may be classified as a mild schizoid. Unfortunately, I cannot continue to understand his situation for he is too refractory to divulge his intimate information.

'Despair in the Pandora's Box - the case of Mr. Y'

I shall attempt to elaborate on this case and develop my theme concurrently.

Mr. Y is a successful, outstanding college student of twenty. His life is quite a legend; he is the kind of man who, after you have been acquainted with him, somehow makes you feel that he is, in some ways, juvenile and whimsical. In fact, he has a young face and always smiles to his acquaintances. But when you know him better, you will probably be aware of the complexity of his thoughts. I have known him for years and it is not long when he came to me, complaining that his self cannot grow and he is dead psychologically. When we were in Form Two, he started to speak about his family. He fell in love with a girl in Form Three but was rejected by her in Lower Six, though he continued to woo her until the beginning of Upper Six. He also frequently reports to me that he loathes his family and constantly rejects his parents.

The following is the biography of the 'client':

The parents of Mr. Y are not rich or happy people. They had been married three years before he was born. They had a daughter before him but she died after birth. His father did not want to have any child then but his mother insisted on having a child before they practised birth control. And Mr. Y was born and reared as the only child of the family. Because of economic circumstances, his mother had to work outside after his birth and he was left to his grandmother for caring in daytime. Nevertheless, his mother would frequently bring back toys to please him in the evening. He developed a strong emotional attachment to his mother. At the age of four, he attended a kindergarten in which he cried a lot. The teachers and almas tried to coax him with toys and all kinds of everything. Eventually, they succeeded in calming him down. But they all went away and were replaced by another group of teachers. He did not stop crying and had to withdraw from school. Then he moved to Hong Kong Island and studied in another kindergarten. He was reported to be a shy, solitary and withdrawn child, never seen playing. Mr. Y can still remember that his mother always took him out with a man called Uncle. He was her intimate friend and took them out for lunch and excursion every Saturday. Mr. Y passed through his subsequent childhood without any noticeable emotional turbulence.

Gradually, he could perceive the pathological interactions inside his family. He said that he could never identify with his father. In fact, his paternal image has never been strong. Instead, he clung to his mother. His mother, he felt, was a very dominant, vain and selfish woman. She always blamed her husband for his low salary and slight prestige, belittling him as a log. Secretly, she told her son that she did

not love her husband. She would start complaining how awkward and useless her husband was and how great and altruistic she was. She also told Mr. Y that he should never resemble his father for he was the most asinine log in the world. If she had a chance, she would not have married this worthless log. The father of Mr. Y was a very passive, docile and awkward man. He had no ambition, no self-determination. In his eyes, his father was a meek ass at best. The school life of Mr. Y was unfortunate. He entered an 'aristocratic' secondary school and was taught by a brutal teacher who debased him to a worthless mass of cells. The tiger form master called him the Lunatic and hit and slapped him, as well as other students frequently. At that time, I was one of his classmate. I knew that he was very unhappy and miserable. However, he started to excel himself in both his academic results and his extra-curricular activities. He became devoted to a girl through whom he could have, at least, an ideal to strive for. But this form of devotion, as far as I know, was pathological. Devoid of any confidence in interpersonal interactions, he simply engaged himself in autistic thinking, dreaming that the girl would love and support him. Finally, the girl rejected him, though he went on to woo her. The girl then did everything to hurt his self-esteem by saying that he was weak, meek and infantile. It did not only enhance his original derivative complex of pathological familial interactions, but also his sense of worthlessness and futility. He was convinced that he was nobody and withdrawn further to his inner world.

Frankly speaking, at the end of Lower Six, Mr. Y was perilously close to psychotic development. It was too painful to face his reality. After matriculation, he went into a post-secondary school and seemed to resume partly his confidence. From the above account, we can see that mawkish family atmosphere can induce a vehement anxiety in growing children. This, in turn, will influence the interpersonal field of them in their future life. They tend to be over-sensitive to human interactions. No hope ever exists for them. There is no intimacy and love in their world, rather, it is filled with danger and uncertainties.

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Man is unique in the respect that he is endowed with self-awareness. Although it has brought man spiritual light, it is also a curse to him. The schizoid or the schizophrenic is the one who has acute self-awareness. He is highly observant of his own processes and thoughts but is a cool, hypercritical judge of them. This form of self-awareness has its origin in the loss of ego identity (or the failure of establishing one) in the history

of development of the individual. Maudlin familial processes tend to arrest the developmental stage of the human organism: he becomes a prey of the Harpies and vanishes in his world without leaving a trace. To bring such people back requires our persistent and continuous effort; we have to penetrate inside their world of despair before we can walk with them and understand them. Small group psychotherapy in Rogerian tradition will probably be a success when applied to such persons. With love and positive regard, I hope that we can, at least, help to alleviate their misery.